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Composing with Old and New Media: Toward a Parallel Pedagogy

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Introduction

When it comes to popular social practices with visual texts among youth, including video gaming, web surfing, and now, uploading short films and television shows to video iPods, it is often unclear to educators what stance we might take (Bruce, 1997). Are such practices a distraction to literacy education, or are they a part of literacy itself? Even if visuals are important, how can we possibly fit more into an already overcrowded curriculum, even if we do decide to buy into an expanded definition of what it means to be literate (Kinzer and Leander, 2003)? Behind such questions is a key issue with important consequences: how do we imagine the relationship of so-called 'new literacies' (Lankshear and Knobel, 2003) to more conventional print-based literacies? In broad strokes, we can describe four common stances on this relationship that are part of our current teaching and research imaginations: resistance, replacement, return and remediation.

The 'resistance' stance involves taking a position squarely with conventional print literacy practices, including reading, interpreting and writing print genres that have been valued in (and out) of school for generations, such as the novel, the academic argument, poetry, the research paper and the like. A stance of resistance may well not be conservation for conservation's sake (as in the innovation curmudgeon or technophobe) but may be a practical response to increased pressure from standards movements to make sure that all children are well educated in conventional literacy practices. Resisters see new literacies, including visual practices, as interfering in the difficult and increasingly assessed business of print literacy practices.

The 'replacement' stance is quite the opposite of that of resistance. Teachers and researchers taking this stance point out the outdatedness and irrelevance of much of what school teaches as literacy. The novel, the academic argument, the poem and the research paper are dead genres, and should be substituted with genres more likely to be found in the native, everyday practices of youth. Film analysis might replace novel interpretation, multimedia persuasion through websites may be a more appropriate set of skills for the future workplace than the academic argument, and the aesthetics of poetry writing and analysis may be better updated by engaging the aesthetics of weblogs. Educators with a replacement stance are often the technophilic counterparts to the technophobia of resisters. In fact, these two stances can serve to perpetuate one another, acting as foils for one another's position.

A common stance that lies somewhere between resistance and replacement may be described as 'return'. By return I mean to indicate a stance that values new literacy practices but validates and defends them with respect to print. The return stance, therefore, is essentially printcentric. Film interpretation or film production is a valued set of activities, but this valuing is primarily measured by how the analysis of still images, moving images, soundtracks and the like scaffold the interpretation and production of conventional literature. In pedagogical practice, new media productions and interpretations do not stand on their own. Rather, new literacy engagements often conclude with print. For instance, if students produce a multimedia project of some type, the project is accompanied by print commentary about what it means and/or about what the composer was thinking while producing it (critiqued by Kist, 2005). This final print piece is considered as a key means of interpreting the value of multi-media engagement.

A final stance may be labelled as 'remediation', which is an imperfect label to indicate not a remedial programme for struggling students, but rather the way in which the meanings and effects of familiar texts and textual forms are communicated, or mediated once again, through less familiar textual forms (Bolter and Grusin, 1999). Relatively 'new' semiotic forms, including the increasing use of visuals in everyday communication, do not abandon old forms, but rather include and embed their generic conventions, structures and practices in new ways. In sum, the new is never entirely apart from the old. A second meaning of the remediation stance for literacy pedagogy is that we are currently in need of understanding the modes of thinking and learning that we want our students to engage in, and consider which media, including print, still and moving images, music, voice, embodied performance, or other that might best 'mediate' such modes of thinking and learning. A remediation stance, therefore, sees different media as neither interfering with one another (as in the resistance stance) nor replacing one another. Moreover, no single means of media (print, visuals or other) assumes a central position in this stance (as in the return stance); the person taking a remediation stance is agnostic with respect to the existence of any supreme media. The creation of meanings and effects upon audiences is of central concern, as are processes of production and interpretation that presume that multimedia is not exceptional, but actually more typical than mono-media.

In this chapter, I assume a stance of remediation as I describe an approach to 'parallel pedagogy' that I am developing in a composition course. Parallel pedagogy is a way of describing how old and new literacy practices, including print texts and visual texts, may be fruitfully taught side by side, rather than the 'old' being a precursor to the new or being replaced by it. In a master's-level composition course, students (pre-service teachers) compose conventional print memoir pieces and they compose digital stories. These digital stories are multimedia compositions that play as short films, and typically involve still images, music tracks, video clips, voice tracks, visual transitions and visual effects. My purpose in having students compose with various media is to expand their conceptual understanding of composition and their practical, working knowledge of different semiotic resources and systems. I strive with my students to build a common meta-level language or grammar of storytelling (memoir) that is functional and valuable across media. Regardless of the media used, for example, storytellers are concerned with conveying some sort of 'big idea' to their audience, and in the course we use language such as 'big idea' and other terms to discuss the possibilities and challenges of composition in different media.

At the same time, in this course we also analyse, discuss and work out ways practically in which different media have different affordances (Gibson, 1979), or ways of functioning that allow them very different potentials to create effects and make meanings. While a print memoir, for instance, might convey a big idea through a repeated key phrase, a photograph might convey its big idea through the way in which the subject is visually framed, or via the angle that the viewer is given with respect to the image subject (Kress and van Leeuwen, 1996). While 'big idea' provides us with a common language, this dimension of storytelling may be worked out in very different ways in distinct media. Moreover, these issues get all the more complex when multiple media are playing at the same time as one another, in different simultaneous tracks of a composition, as in the case of digital storytelling.

In what follows, the discussion of parallel pedagogy proceeds in two main sections. First, I offer a broad overview of the composition course, expanding on the introduction given thus far. Second, I discuss specific course activities that are structured to scaffold students' understandings of how visuals, in story composition, may be understood through a set of dimensions that also relate to print and other media. In the final part of the second section, I focus on one student's project to offer a more detailed view of how parallel pedagogy functions and the kinds of thinking and learning it fosters.

Overview of 'Teaching composition by traversing "old" and "new" media'

'Teaching composition' is a composition pedagogy course offered to master's students at Vanderbilt who are preparing to teach English at the secondary school level. The course approaches the activity of composing with 'an expanded tool

kit' (Smagorinski, 2002) that includes, but is not limited to, print. The course is created to value and scaffold students' understandings of print composition without limiting the notion of composing to print media; the fact that we use 'compose' and 'composition' to describe the activity and products of writers, visual artists and sculptors alike is taken as an invitation to explore how composing shares something in common across media. This approach to common dimensions across media is framed, in relation to the personal memoir, by examining several 'dimensions' of composition that are relevant across diverse media. For example, within print memoirs, voice may be defined as the 'speaking personality' of the writer (Bakhtin, 1986). Yet, in composing and arranging photographs or other visual texts, we also recognize something akin to the personality of the composer – her or his persona communicating through the images. In this manner, we may also discuss the 'voice' of the photographer. In considering a music or recorded voice track, by contrast, we might consider material qualities of voice that are not easily afforded by print or visuals, including timbre, resonance and pitch. Hence, the notion of 'voice' remains highly meaningful across media. These kinds of considerations and comparisons are key to what I intend by developing a parallel pedagogy. Other dimensions considered include transition, focus or 'big idea', place and time, and others.

Students in 'Teaching composition' create a multimedia digital story as a final class project that is five to ten minutes in length, and is based on earlier versions of a print memoir that they have written. We use (Apple) iMovie in this project as the learning curve with iMovie is not steep. Final stories are presented in a Digital Story Film Festival at the end of the semester. Along with this product- and audience-focus of the course, students are assigned a number of in-progress composition assignments, including two different written memoirs, an image memoir piece, a storyboard and others. These assignments draw on and juxtapose different media, including print but also sound voice recordings and images. Thus, a large degree of process work in both print and non-print media precedes the final production of the digital story. Additionally, these pieces are produced through peer response and revising groups, a process that is familiar within writing-process pedagogies (for example, Atwell, 1998). Many students who have taken the course have reported that one of its major effects on them was to be convinced of the importance of response and revision during the composing process. It appears that there is a particular visual and material relationship provided by working on multimedia that makes the idea of revision and response more immediately and powerfully visible than working in print alone. For example, in the multimedia workshop environment, students share pictures, music tracks and tips for creating particular effects for others' projects to a degree that I have not experienced when students respond to print texts alone.

Parallel pedagogy with pictures

The three following examples are of specific lessons and activities intended to juxtapose the interpretation and creation of images with that of print texts.

These examples of parallel pedagogy, drawn from 'Teaching composition', are intended here to suggest a pedagogical orientation from which a broad range of lessons and learning experiences could be developed.

Analysis of big idea in print and digital stories

Roorbach (1998, p. 55) notes that the big idea of a written piece is a broader notion than the notion of thesis; the idea is the 'underlying conception or conceptions that give a piece of successful writing its unity – the kind of unity that plot sometimes brings to fiction'. As a writing teacher, it has often surprised me how difficult it is for students to learn the related notions of 'guiding idea', 'big idea', or 'thesis'. It seems as if second graders through to adult writers struggle with the same problem in different texts. In memoir-writing at the secondary school level, I've often noticed how some of my students seem to catch on quickly to the subtle ways in which a skilled writer makes the underlying conception of her memoir come to life, while other students seem to write personal essays or memoirs that either lack a central conception or have it mercilessly tagged on ('And that's when I learned that it always pays to be prepared.'). Throughout the entire process of working on print memoirs and digital stories, we talk a great deal about the notion of 'big idea', but early on in the process we also deliberately analyse memoir pieces in print and other pieces as digital stories to make explicit comparisons about how their big ideas are conveyed. In the following, I give a sense of this activity by drawing on one student's observational notes and comparisons.

A print memoir piece that I like to use is the story 'Adjustments', by Jeanne Brinkman Grinnan (Kitchen and Jones, 1999). 'Adjustments' is a lovely, haunting piece that is just over a page in length, a kind of still life of a mother setting and winding the house clocks as her daughter looks on. Nothing happens in the story, which is made meaningful by how the event it shot through with the narrator's memories of the father, who took on this task himself along with other activities requiring his meticulous attention. The clock-setting calls up themes of time being marked and passing in the midst of loss, just as the mother's position atop a chair, as she winds the clocks, calls up themes of balance at risk. 'Kate', a student in my class, wrote the following observational notes about how the big idea of 'Adjustments' was conveyed:

Clocks (uncaptured time) metaphor/physical symbol for something bigger than self; details connect to themes.
Example: falling mother, changing clock, taking out trash.
Repetition.

One of the digital stories that I use for conveying the dimension of big idea is 'BJ's Story', from the website Silence Speaks (www.silencespeaks.org). Like the other stories at this site, 'BJ's Story' is a story about experiencing violence, in this case, through the words of a boy observing his alcoholic father continually abusing his mother. The story is told in poetic form, with a rap rhythm, and the

visuals move across photos, abstract art and symbolic images. Kate's observational notes on the big idea in 'BJ's Story' were as follows:

Zoom and camera focus/out of focus
Hand in chains, repeated images
Repeated beat – idea carried on
Flashback to kid and kid's eyes
'All I could do was watch her hands.'
'Internally bleed' – language is poignant.
Coupling of religious images/plaster/violence.

After comparing several print and multimedia stories, I asked the students to synthesize their thoughts about how 'big idea' functions in similar and different ways in print and non-print. Kate drew out some thoughtful initial comparisons in this activity. Among them, she noted that both print and digital stories 'pay attention to details as a way of showing main ideas'. Kate especially noted that 'deliberate and purposeful' word choice in both forms of storytelling was essential to shaping the big idea. Additionally, she pointed out that print and visual texts function with repetitions of certain figures, and pointed out as an example the clocks in 'Adjustments' and images of hands (for abuse) within 'BJ's Story'. In terms of differences, or the specific affordances of print versus multimedia storytelling, Kate remarked that the relations among the music and images and soundtrack, in digital stories, serve to establish the main idea, and offered as an example the steady rhythmic beat that gave a pulsing, menacing background tone to 'BJ's Story'. While Kate noticed that different media might work together in the digital stories, she also made an important observation that media may move in different directions: 'digital (media) can show irony through juxtaposition of "mismatched" pictures, music, words, etc.' By contrast, a special affordance that Kate remarked about print media was that it could present a less distracting main idea; while media could work together (or intentionally apart), multiple media tracks could also just simply be distracting if not produced well.

In class, we often used this broad type of observation, inquiry and synthesis activity to consider how different dimensions of composition are realized in print and non-print texts (digital stories, film, still images, comic strips, and so on). Of course, the variation among stories within any particular media (for example, print stories as a category) may also be very great; we cannot make easy claims about how just a few stories stand for an entire media type. However, by looking closely, comparing, synthesizing and filtering one's thinking through a key dimension such as 'big idea', students begin to develop ways of looking and analysing that could readily lead to and motivate more detailed or technical analyses.

Transition workshop: verbal and visual grammars

The transition workshop is relatively simply structured as an inquiry into the

functions and differences among linguistic and visual transitions. I begin this workshop with a discussion of common linguistic transitions and transitional phrases in print texts and their various functions, using a list such as that offered by the Department of Rhetoric and Composition at Oberlin College (www.oberlin.edu/rhetoric/writing/assist/paragraphs.html), excerpted below:

- To show cause and effect: therefore, thus, consequently, as a result, for this reason, so, so that
- To compare: however, on the one hand/on the other hand, in contrast, conversely, but, yet, nevertheless, nonetheless, on the contrary, still
- To show addition: and, in addition, also, furthermore, moreover, besides
- To indicate time: before, now, after, afterwards, subsequently, later, earlier, meanwhile, in the meantime, while, as long as, so far.

Of course, the skill of creating effective transitions in print cannot be limited to learning a list of terms; we also discuss other means of transitioning between sentences and paragraphs, including referring to old information, repeating key words and providing top-level language and headings so that readers can make their way through long pieces.

After discussing linguistic transitions, and looking specifically at their use within different stories and other print texts, I ask the students to view the transitions provided by iMovie, which are a subset of a much larger group of transitions used in film, and to describe the meaning that they believe each transition has. The transitions used in a recent version of iMovie included *blow*, *circle closing*, *circle opening*, *cross dissolve*, *fade in*, *overlap*, *push*, *radial*, *ripple* and several others. Filmic transitions are difficult to represent as still images, but the images in Figures 9.1, 9.2 and 9.3 suggest something of the range of what students would be seeing in iMovie.

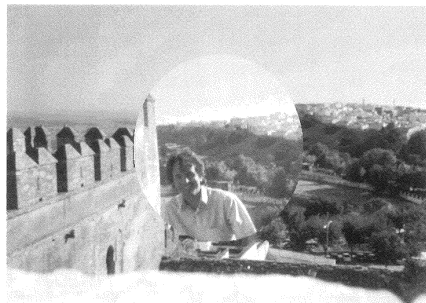


Figure 9.1 Circle closing transition

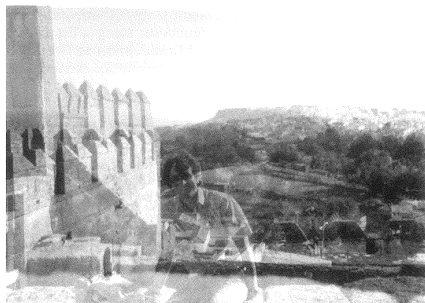


Figure 9.2 Cross dissolve transition

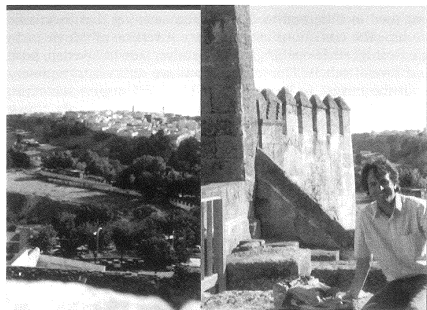


Figure 9.3 Push transition

As they view these various transitions, the students fill in a chart that offers verbal equivalents of the meanings of these visuals. For example, in an excerpt of one student's work (Table 9.1), she indicated that cross dissolve carried a meaning of cause and effect, such as is conveyed by the word 'consequently', and, by contrast, that the push transition indicated time moving forward, such as in

the word 'subsequently', or perhaps simultaneity with a right to left push. Other students had different ideas, worthy of comparison and discussion. My concern in this activity is not that students identify a single correct (verbal) meaning for (visual) film transitions. In fact, it is certain that some visual transitions have no verbal equivalent at all, and that movement in the opposite direction is also incomplete. Rather, my key goal is that students develop a meta-level approach to considering how transitions are a dimension that composers in print and film routinely address, and that the functions of transitions in expressing relations among ideas, movements in space and time, causes and effects, comparisons and other relations are functions that traverse media. In order to push students' parallel thinking about transitions, I ask them, alone or in pairs, to write a short paragraph comparing verbal and visual transitions, based upon their enquiry. In the following, one student begins to suggest his understanding of visual transitions as having unique meanings:

Table 9.1 Student comparisons of visual and verbal (print) transitions

iMovie	Print text (student responses)
Billow	To give example, to illustrate, for example
Circle closing	To emphasize a point: in fact
Circle opening	To conclude or summarize, in summary
Cross dissolve	Cause & effect, consequently
Fade in	To introduce; at first
Overlap	To show cause & effect; for this reason; as a result
Push	To indicate time: subsequently, meanwhile (depends on which way you push)

In iMovie, different transitions have distinct implications: a push, for instance, a different relationship than a cross-dissolve, just as the expressions 'instead of' and 'however' evoke different relationships in print. Across media, transitions connect ideas, show relationships and heighten the drama. Equivalencies or connections seem to exist across media.

At the same time that this student noted similar transition functions across media, in his analysis he also argued that print offered a greater range of 'specific and subtle' transitions than film: 'For example, are there equivalent transitional devices like "nonetheless" and "furthermore" in non-print domains?' This type of response gave us the opportunity to discuss how print may have greater affordances for certain kinds of logical connections, while film has unique and unusual affordances for space-time relationships. Moreover, discussion based on these initial analyses readily turns to the simultaneity of transitions across different media tracks within film – where, for instance, a music track, rhythm or voice-over may continue while visuals shift (or vice versa). Further, a number of students noted how the meanings of visual transitions were highly dependent upon the particulars of the visuals themselves. Had I picked up on this insight earlier, it could have provided a

cussed as setting up the scene, and perhaps even suggesting some initial separation between the viewer and the scene. Additionally, Gunther Kress and Theo Van Leeuwen (1996) have developed productive means of considering how horizontal angles with respect to photographic subjects carry meaning, and also how subjects are photographed as relatively objectified (in a position of 'offer' to the viewer) or as directly engaging the viewer (in a position of 'demand').

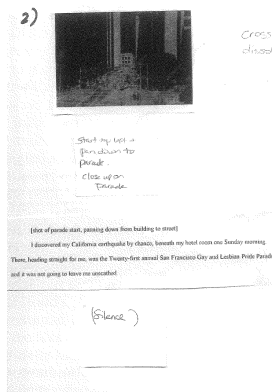


Figure 9.5 Todd's storyboard, frame 2

Scene-building with images and playing with place and time

As Todd re-mediate his print memoir into a multimedia story, not only does he develop meanings through parallel media tracks, he also, visually, develops the way in which he is producing scenes in the story and is transforming the relations of space and time. While his earlier print memoir had only a fleeting reference to there not being much of a gay community in Tennessee, in his digital story Todd sets up this contrast visually through two counter-posed scenes: a photograph of the Bay Bridge that transitions into a photograph of a road sign for 'The Other Side Club', a gay nightclub in rural Tennessee, which then shifts to an image of the club building itself (Figure 9.6). When Todd set out to visually represent the idea of the lack of a gay community in Tennessee, his selected visuals developed into a short scene in the story, which itself prompted him to develop his writing about Tennessee for use in his voice-over. The movements from print to visual and back to print generate new ideas. Moreover, in having produced this new scene of the Other Side Club, we begin to see in this

example how the story begins to play with space and time, shifting from the narrator's present position in San Francisco, back to Tennessee, and returning to San Francisco again. While this is a small example, I have observed that my students seem much more prone to play with such space-time arrangements in composing when they are engaged in visual arrangement and other forms of media work than when they are not. Of course, this observation is not surprising, since a quality of film production has involved such play for decades.

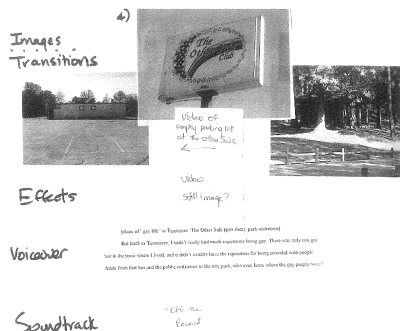


Figure 9.6 Todd's storyboard, frame 3

Contrasts through simultaneous images and texts

As noted previously, Todd added new voice-over text to his digital story to tell us how to interpret the visual of Tennessee gay life, or the image of The Other Side Club:

There was only one gay bar in the town where I lived, and it didn't exactly have the reputation for being crowded with people. Aside from that bar and the public restrooms in the city park, who even knew where the gay people were? (Figure 9.6)

An important characteristic of this print text is not merely that it runs parallel to the photograph, but that it develops an ironic relationship to it. Of course, one might interpret the tone of the print text alone ('exactly have the reputation ...') as ironic, but the image, and the slow pan out from it across the empty parking lot, drive this point home with greater effect. Todd comments on others' responses to this ironic relationship of image to voice-over text and pan:

I was sort of saying something really sarcastic about how it was always really crowded with people. That ended up drawing laughs in a way that I kind of expected it to because the timing just with my voiceover and then the pan out of the video worked really well.

This use of visuals and print (or other media) as sharply contrasting with one another, and leading to interpretations of irony, of gaps, of disagreement, of discordant voices, of humour or other, suggests a more advanced understanding of the simultaneous relationship of visuals to print text than is evident in the work of some students, who favour seeing one medium as necessarily illustrating or complementing the other.

Conclusions

In literacy education, we find ourselves in a strange time period in which movements pull us in disparate directions. On the one hand, educators are under great pressure to ensure that all students can compose conventional academic prose for standardized assessments. On the other hand, many of the literacy practices that students engage in outside of school increasingly involve visuals and other media, and these practices seem increasingly remote from conventional academic prose. In this chapter, I offer an invitation to return to basic questions and bridging ways of thinking concerning composition. I argue that we need to back off from the products of composition, whether these are scholarly arguments, nature photographs, or musical scores, and consider thoughtfully how certain meta-level processes and dimensions of composition have powerful purchase across media. Using the case of composing personal memoir, I consider how personal memoir contains a number of dimensions that retain their importance and impact, regardless of media.

Through course description, lesson outlines, student work and student reflection, I illustrate how we might move toward a parallel pedagogy of 'old' print and 'new' non-print media, a pedagogy that I believe has benefits for present-day learning as well as for future literate practice. The examples given show something of how learning becomes powerful when it is driven by comparison and analogy, and when it is enacted across multiple forms of mediation. This kind of learning is restless and mobile, always seeking to understand one thing in terms of another; just as English grammar might be first understood through the study of French grammar, the print memoir is compared with the digital story, and the linguistic transition is understood through the visual transition. Of course, as discussed in the chapter, visuals and other media cannot be entirely understood or contained through their relations to print or other media. Yet, despite these limitations, the act of comparison itself helps us understand key distinctions between media types.

In addition to offering outcomes for immediate learning, ongoing movements towards parallel pedagogy could be promising for addressing

some of the disparate demands that schools are facing. Indeed, it seems entirely untenable to imagine that essayist-based prose will be all that is needed for literacy success in work, leisure, and life pursuits in the 21st century. Yet, to take a stance of replacement of the old by the new, or of return to the old in rejection of the new is to ignore the repeated ways in which history has shown us how the old is absorbed and routinely transformed into new forms (Bolter and Grusin, 1999); we live within our history and beyond it, simultaneously. To deliberately juxtapose the old and new, then – print and pictures – might just make good pedagogic sense, as they seem to be continually chasing one another around anyway, concerned as they both are with telling a good story.

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Websites with digital story examples and information
Capture Wales
www.bbc.co.uk/wales/capturewales

Center for Digital Storytelling

www.storycenter.org

City Voices, City Visions

www.gse.buffalo.edu/org/cityvoices/productions.html

Dana Atchley's Next Exit

www.nextexit.com

Design Examples and Communities

www.bubbe.com, www.fray.com, www.links.net, www.alexrivera.com, <http://cultureisaweapon.org>, www.creativenarrations.net, www.zonezero.com

www.digiclub.org

Digital Clubhouse Network

www.digiclub.org

Digital Storytelling Association

www.dsaweb.org

Digital Storytelling Festival

www.dstory.com

Hillary McLellan's Story Link

<http://tech-head.com/dstory.htm>

(No stories here, but a good list of links to sites with other approaches to digital communication.)

Silence Speaks

www.silencespeaks.org/stories.html

Stories of Service

www.stories-of-service.org/theproject/

(Select 'See Our Work' near the bottom of the page.)

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Key points

1. 'New' media has features and dimensions of 'old' media within it, and these connections between new and old media can be a powerful tool for learning about multimedia production and interpretation.
2. In addition to connections between old and new media, particular media have certain affordances, or possibilities for functioning that allow them very different potentials to create effects and make meanings.
3. When students remediate messages from one medium to another they develop new understandings of their intended messages and different media.

In your classroom

1. A common shortcoming of student experiments in new media production is that they focus on technical surface features at the expense of more meaningful generic qualities. In teaching multimedia production, it is helpful to go back to basic concepts of the genre you are working in and ask your students what makes that particular genre effective. For instance, good stories have a sense of a narrator's voice, no matter what media they appear in.
2. Using a language of 'composition' or 'design' across different media types, as well as compositional terms that readily traverse media (for example, 'big idea', 'transition', 'structure') can help your students develop a richer understanding of composing across media and building relations between simultaneous media.
3. Give students the opportunity to engage in observation, inquiry, comparison and synthesis concerning how particular dimensions of composition function in different media examples. Strive in this work to not give primacy to any medium, but rather to show the unique affordances of media types, as well as how particular composers and pieces make use of these affordances and simultaneous media.

Further reading

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